BENGALI

Paper 3204/01
Composition

General comments

This year candidates performed quite well overall. Almost all candidates answered both parts of the paper as required. For the answers in ***Section A***, candidates who referred to individual bullet points with good vocabulary, correct spelling, varied sentence structures and tenses scored relatively higher marks. Some candidates lost marks due to the lack of good presentation, missing reference to the bullet points, spelling errors, dialectical language and improper use of tenses or idioms. In ***Section B***, the candidates who showed a good reference to the essay title across their work, established their own thoughts with logic, consistency, idiomatic language, correct spelling, varied sentence structures and tenses were awarded higher marks. Some candidates wrote answers that were too long or too short, deviated from the original theme, used inconsistent spellings which led to lower marks. A small number of candidates wrote one answer and changed their mind to write another one from the same option group but forgot to cross out either which must be avoided.

Comments on specific questions

Section A

Question 1

Candidates were required to write a letter to their friend describing a music festival. All those who attempted this question wrote a very realistic answer from their personal experience of an enjoyable event. A small number of candidates tried to imagine a fun fair or a cultural festival and gave an account of a wide range of cultural events so they were awarded only for the parts that were relevant to music festival. Some candidates also omitted to answer certain parts of the bullet points, hence they lost marks. It is therefore recommended that the candidates should read all parts of the question and give a realistic account of the specific event as demanded in the question.

Question 2

In this section, candidates need to write a speech for the celebration of 'International Mother Tongue Day' in their school. Those who attempted this performed very well. Most candidates presented their speech in a very realistic way with valid suggestions for the school and society to play their respective role in sustaining their mother tongue. A small number of candidates missed the reference to certain bullet points hence scored lower marks.

Question 3

Candidates are required to write an essay on their 'Experience of a journey by boat.' The overall quality of this response was quite good. For most candidates it was a realistic narration of their personal experience. Each candidate seems to have taken a great interest in narrating their real life experiences which helped them to bring originality to their work, although there were some occasional slips. A small number of candidates lost marks due to deviation, inconsistency, spelling and other grammatical errors. It is advised that the candidates proofread their work prior to submission.

Question 4

In this question candidates are expected to write an essay about 'A remarkable scientific invention that has significantly influenced your life'. Some candidates presented their work with numerous realistic examples and their personal opinion with logical arguments which helped them score high marks. However a few

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candidates deviated from the original theme and omitted to give any example of its influence in their personal life hence lost some marks. In order to achieve high marks candidates must read carefully every word of the essay title to address the question's demand.

Question 5

Candidates are required to write an essay about 'The importance of vocational education'. A small number of candidates who wrote this essay performed mostly well. However a few candidates wrote from their memorised language about the importance of education in general rather than vocational, hence they scored relatively low. It is essential that the candidates read every word of the essay title. Candidates also need to be mindful about the word limit, accuracy of spelling and appropriate use of idioms to achieve higher marks.

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Paper 3204/02
Language Usage and Comprehension

Key message

To do well on this paper, candidates should:

- write accurately;
- use a wide range of vocabulary and structures;
- provide a range of well-developed ideas;
- ensure their essays are fully relevant to the chosen topic, well organised and coherent.

General comments

Candidates were tested on their knowledge of grammar, manipulation of sentences and comprehension skills through a variety of tasks. The majority of candidates completed the paper within the time allowed. There were very few examples of unfinished or partially answered questions. The performances of several candidates were outstanding, though there were examples of candidates who could have performed better had they practised their exam technique. Generally speaking, most candidates coped well with basic grammar tasks and the comprehension questions though at a varied level. The quality of the Bengali in answers was very wide. Some candidates demonstrated the ability to manipulate the language very skilfully. There were also instances where candidates were unable to write answers in their own words, even at a very simple level. It should be noted that candidates who rely too heavily on the text cannot gain access to the higher marks for the quality of their language. On the other hand, attempts to write answers that make the effort to manipulate language are rewarded more generously, even when this results in increased accuracy, provided that it does not interfere with comprehension.

Comments on specific questions

Section A

Question A1

This question comprises the task to combine five words. This task was quite straightforward except **A1(3)** and **A1(5)** where a number of candidates struggle to combine the words correctly. A large number of candidates found **A1(3)** difficult. Instead of the correct answer শোকার্ত they have written শোর্কাত or শোকৃত. The other common mistake was observed in answers for **Question 4**. Here many candidates have written ব্যাবস্থা instead of ব্যবস্থা. For **Question 5**, a significant number of candidates have written নিঙ্কার instead of নিরাকার.

Only the most able candidates scored full marks in this question.

Question A2

This question comprises a gap-filling task followed by idioms, proverbs and words in pairs to be lifted in the appropriate gaps in five set sentences. The majority of candidates were able to answer this question correctly, though there were instances where a number of candidates struggled to lift the correct idioms/proverbs/words in pairs. **A2(6)**, and **A2(7)** posed confusion to many candidates. Here also only the most able ones scored the total marks.

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Question A3

The task comprises transforming sentences based on clues at the beginning of the sentence. Less able candidates found this question challenging. They often struggled to manipulate particularly the essence of **A3(12)** and **A3(13)** appropriately and so scored worse when answering **Question A3(13)**. They have just copied the question such as কঠিন পরিশ্রম কে না করতেপারে। Many candidates found **Question A(14)** very challenging. Many candidates wrote তোমার গানের প্রশংসা কী সকলেই করে. In answering **Question 15**, many students failed to transform the sentence into indirect speech. Some of them just copied the question by removing the speech mark. One requirement was to change আমি to তুমি which many candidates failed to do, so they scored fewer marks.

Question A4

Performance in this section was mixed. Very few candidates answered all the questions correctly. Candidates found **Question A4(17)** the most accessible. Except for one or two, almost all the candidates answered this correctly. **Question A4(21)** was also answered correctly by many candidates. Answers for **Questions A4(22)**, **A4(23)** and **A4(24)** were often chosen at random. Many candidates mixed these up. However, weaker candidates often struggled to lift and match correct words for the gaps. **Questions A4(16)** and **A4(17)** posed problems.

Section B5 (MCQ comprehension)

Again, unlike the previous year, the performance on this section was very good. By and large, candidates have answered them correctly. Most candidates answered **Questions 28** to **31** correctly. In answering **Question 26**, many candidates wrote **B** instead of **D**. Similarly, **Question 32** was also answered incorrectly by several students. They wrote **D** in place of **B**.

Section C6 (OE comprehension)

This question comprises of OE comprehension followed by a set questionnaire. The majority of candidates performed well on this question particularly on **33**, **35**, **36**, **37** and **38**. However, **Questions 35** and **36** posed a challenge to a number of candidates and so they confused the answers for **Question 36** and put them for **Question 35**. Some used materials from the answers for **Question 38** such as বাড়ি বাড়ি গিয়ে মা বাবাকে বোঝাতেলাগল or ছাত্রী সংখ্যা ক্রমশ বারতে লাগল ইত্যাদি। Most candidates scored full marks for **Question 38**.

Question C7 (Vocabulary)

On this question, candidates were expected to write the appropriate meaning of five words lifted from the comprehension text. This question particularly, **Questions 39**, **40** and **42** was challenging for most candidates.

This was the most challenging section. On the whole performance was quite poor. Very few students scored full marks in this section. **Question 39** was the best answered. However, many students lost marks because of spelling mistakes. Instead of ঢুকা, many have written ডোকা, ধোকা, বিতরে আসা etc.

In answering **Question 40**, some candidates used ব্যস্ত, জীবিত। For answering **Question 42** many candidates have written অবাক, দুর্বল। The most challenging question was **Question 39**. Very few candidates answered this question correctly. They answered with words like জমিয়ে, খরচ, which do not have any bearing with the meaning of নিঃশেষ।

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